



It only takes a village

A livelihood project works hard to make dreams come true in the North-East

■ By Swagata Sen

The first thing that strikes you about the International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD) team is its dedication. K. Moses Chalai, programme coordinator, is an IAS officer who is a flesh-and-blood version of Agastya Sen in Upamanyu Chatterjee's *English, August*, but without the dope-addiction. Brimming with facts and figures, his team explains its role in the largest social livelihood project in the North-East, the North Eastern Region Community Resource Management Project for Upland Areas (NERCORMP). A

joint effort with the North Eastern Council and the Ministry of Development of North Eastern Region, the project is spread over six districts in three states and has made a difference to the lives of over a lakh people.

For the past eight years, NERCORMP has been the biggest rural project in the region, disproving the perception that such projects fail in the strife-torn North-East. It will fold up in March next year, paving the way for a much bigger project funded by the World Bank. The Washington-

based institution had for years been wary of entering the region and has only relented because of the project's success. The project has also formed self-help groups, enabling women to have a voice in the traditional authority system of the tribes. Today a woman like Lerneihoi, a widow who lives in a village called Ichum Keirap, has been able to garner an annual income of Rs 25,000 with just an initial loan of Rs 1,000. A little hand-holding always helps, and she is thankful to IFAD. What's more, she is not alone.

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VILLAGES ARE
AIDED BY
NERCORMP



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Manipuri women at work in an orchard

SUVASHISH MULLICK